



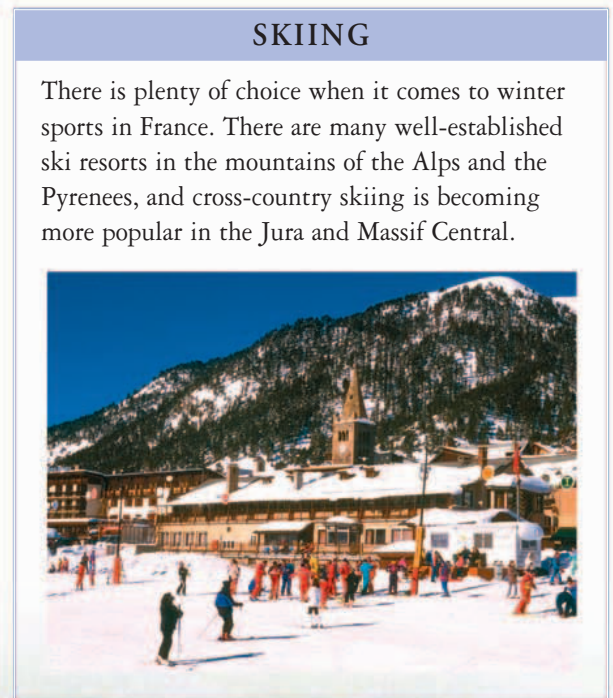
Away from the cities

France enjoys great geographical diversity and each region has its own distinct character and food. Particular areas of natural beauty include Brittany with its rugged coast, the mountain ranges of the Alps and the Pyrenees, the Mediterranean coast around the Cote d'Azur, and the glorious vineyards and lavender fields of Provence.



WEEKLY MARKETS

Many French towns host weekly markets where farmers sell their own produce ranging from fruit and vegetables to wine, sausages, and cheeses. The foods vary according to the region and season.



SKIING

There is plenty of choice when it comes to winter sports in France. There are many well-established ski resorts in the mountains of the Alps and the Pyrenees, and cross-country skiing is becoming more popular in the Jura and Massif Central.

FRAGRANT FIELDS

The lavender plant needs little water and grows well in the dry, hot climate of southern France. Its sweet fragrance makes it a popular ingredient in soaps and perfumes. It has one additional quality—it is a strong natural insect repellent.

Provence is well-known for its acres of lavender fields, which are harvested at the height of the summer.

